

have to relax. We must be able help our clients be curious and compassionate by being curious and compassionate ourselves. This is what we call being Self-led.

What we know can help us be and remain Self-led throughout therapy. We know that exiled emotions and memories are connected to the client's addictive process. And once we get to know a client, we understand why their protectors deploy when they do, even if the client doesn't recognize the association at first. We also know that inner critics work hard in an addictive system, so we get curious about parts who are critical of other parts or who blame other people. To help clients make this connection, we invite them to slow down, turn their attention inside, notice what happened in the days or hours before they gave into an addictive urge, and notice what they feel right now. We know their needy parts feel desperate and abandoned. And we know that internal matters must improve before the client will try any new behaviors. Therefore, we do therapy with a system, not a symptom.

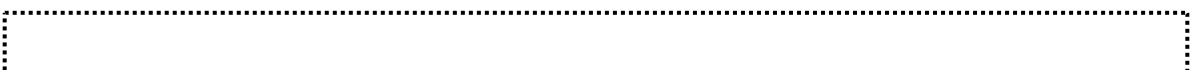
THE ADDICTION POLARITY

As you treat clients who are engaged in addictive processes, keep the following information front and center in your mind. Polarized protector teams are the norm in addictive processes—and these teams have very different perspectives. For managers, engaging in the compulsive behavior is like volunteering to drown. For firefighters, abstinence is like throwing your life jacket away as the waters are rising. As a result, it's good to consider whom you're talking with. If you're only hearing from one side, you can be assured that the other side exists and will take the floor at some point. To avoid reinforcing polarized conflicts, it's best to just assume that the client has long been bombarded with differing views about using, stopping using, and even showing up for an assessment interview or first session—and avoid taking a side.

If your head is spinning because the client is being obviously contradictory—for example, saying, “I have to stop drinking!” and “Why is everyone so uptight about what I do after work?”—that means you're listening to an argument between the two teams in real time. In this case, your best option is to call the game: “I hear a part who wants to stop drinking... Now I hear a part who doesn't want to stop drinking.” Combine your nonjudgmental interest with a light, polite tone that will signal to firefighters—the ones who are hardest to engage—that you might confound their negative expectations.

If the client starts therapy by complaining about having to be in therapy, someone in their life probably pushed them to get treatment and you're listening to a firefighter complain (as we illustrated in the example of Roger, whose wife pressed him to seek therapy). In this case, mirror back, validate the part's feelings about other people weighing in on their habit, and then guide the client to notice their manager team by soliciting contrary views: “Other people are concerned about you using. Do you ever say something similar to yourself? Like *I need to cut back. That headache is just too big when I get up in the morning. I'm tired of feeling sick every day or I'm worried that things are getting worse.*” As illustrated with Roger, you may need to repeat this question a few times before the client admits to having a managerial perspective on using. But once they do, you can state the polarity in plain language and guide them to ask both teams to the table to talk with their Self.

If, on the other hand, the client is worried about their level of use (or a particular consequence of using) and comes to therapy of their own incentive, you're talking with a manager and you can use the standard IFS approach: “You've come to therapy because you want to cut back on drinking, but you feel ambivalent. So one part of you wants to cut back, but another part wants a drink at the end of the day. Is that right? Let's hear from both of those parts. Does anyone object?” From this point, you can explore the polarity and help polarized protectors unblend simultaneously using the following techniques.



IDENTIFYING AN ADDICTIVE POLARITY

Here is summary of steps to take to unpack the addictive polarity:

- Start by inviting the client to discuss what they wish were different. Are they looking for a behavioral shift, a modification, or a new vision?
- Listen closely to the client's description of themselves and other people. If they are blended with a manager, they will sound critical and anxious and push for change. If they are blended with a firefighter, they will defend their substance use or compulsive behavior and dismiss the risks. If they are blended with an exile, they will sound hopeless, lost, and ashamed.
- Notice if any of your parts respond to this narrative with fear, judgment, or the urge to caretake, and ask these parts to unblend.
- Explain to the client that each of their parts has a role that fits into one of three categories, and ask permission to reflect what you are hearing back in parts language so you can illustrate these roles.
- Ask the client to visualize and identify each part. Make a list of the parts who have showed up, and ask the client to place them on two teams and visualize them in separate spaces.
- Acknowledge that both sides are entrenched and feel trapped, that some of their behaviors are risky, and that consequences are accruing.
- Identify the positive intentions of each side, and point out that both teams are trying to help despite the fact that they view each other as enemies. They are both trying to keep the system in balance. Normalize their polarity.
- Assert that each team is more complex than it looks. Invite them to see each other in a new way.
- Check in to see how this new perspective is landing with the client. Invite the two teams to connect with the Self, who can help everyone by taking care of exiled parts.
- Offer hope: *There is never an excuse, but there are always reasons, and we can address those reasons.*

Therapist Handout**Triangle Mapping for a Polarized System**

Once you identify a client's addictive polarity, map it onto a triangle, which will show the client how their exiles and protectors interact. To begin, invite the client to draw an inverted triangle. Label managers at the top left point and firefighters at the top right point. Place the exile (or exiles) at the bottom point.

Then invite the client to turn their attention inside and notice their managers. List these parts at the manager point of the triangle. Next, have them once again turn their attention inside and notice their firefighters. List these parts at the firefighter point of the triangle. Finally, invite them to notice any exiles that come up during the exercise and to list these parts at the bottom of the triangle. (Instead of writing down their parts, the client may prefer to draw their parts or choose figures to represent their parts using sand tray toys, IFS-inspired cards, magazine cutouts, and so on.)

Once the client finishes listing all of their parts, ask them to jot down the intentions and fears of both protective teams and of the exile. The client may wish to draw solid lines between parts who are particularly allied and broken lines to show which parts are most in conflict. When the triangle drawing is complete, here are some questions you may want to ask:

- What do you observe now?
- How do you feel now?
- Which part-to-part relationships stand out?
- Which parts are most polarized?
- How do you feel toward your exile(s)?
- Have you met all of these parts before?
- Which part (or polarity) wants your attention first?
- What does this part (choose one specific part to focus on) want from you?

When this process is complete, thank the parts who showed up and save the triangle for future sessions. If the client wants, they can take it home and keep adding parts or details about the motives of the parts they know to date.

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Therapist Handout

Strategies for Helping Polarized Parts Unblend at the Same Time

When protectors can't trust each other because they are extremely at odds, we ask them to unblend at the same time. The techniques described here—the conference table, the two-hand scale, connecting in the body—all facilitate simultaneous unblending.

1. The Conference Table

The conference table is a user-friendly exercise in which the client's Self welcomes their risk-taking firefighter team, their controlling manager team, and their exiles to sit together at a table. This can become a recurring intervention that the client can evoke at home as well.

First, ask the client to sit at the head of a big conference table. Next, invite the protective teams to sit on opposite sides of the table, while exiles take a seat across from the client's Self, at the foot of the table. Once everyone is arranged, be sure that the client's Self is present at the head of the table. If not, the client can ask the part who is sitting in for them to join its team and to let the Self sit down.

Next, guide the client to validate both the firefighter and manager teams for their positive intentions, and assert that each of them is needed. They may want to get rid of each other, but the Self intends to keep everyone on board. Invite them to shift their gaze away from the others, look to the Self, and consider the possibility that they no longer have to challenge or fix each other because the Self will help the exiles they protect and set them free.

Then ask who needs attention first. When a target part (or team) volunteers, ask the client how they feel toward this part (or team). If they say something negative, help the reactive part unblend. You might need to facilitate some shuttle diplomacy to illustrate that the Self can handle both teams. Then listen to the target part (or team), validate its good intentions, explore the pros and cons of what it does, and ask if it is ready to try something new. Then do the same with the other side.

Finally, ask if it would be good for everyone if the Self could help the exiles that these two teams protect. When they agree, ask the client what they notice in their body now. If protectors are unblending, they will name a sense of space or calm or something along those lines. If exiles activate, invite them to sit with the Self. Reassure everyone that the Self is committed to the whole system and that no one is alone.*

2. The Two-Hand Scale

The two-hand scale is another way of helping polarized protectors unblend at simultaneously. To practice this exercise, invite the client to hold their hands palm up. Then instruct the client to close their eyes as you say, "Don't think. Put one part in one hand and the other part in the other hand. Which hand weighs more?" Then ask each hand, "What is your message?" End by asking the client, "How do you feel now toward these polarized teams now?"

3. Connect in the Body

Connecting in the body is another way to help polarized parts simultaneously unblend. To guide clients through this exercise, invite them to identify two parts (or teams of parts) who are in conflict with each other—where do they show up in the client’s body? Then ask the parts if they notice the client. If not, ask if they are willing to notice the client.

Once they are willing, ask which part needs attention first, and guide the client to send breath, or perhaps a thread of light, to that part while saying, “You are not alone.” What does this part want the client to know? It may use words or any preferred way of communicating. Do the same with the second part or team of parts. Assert that there is plenty of space in the body for all parts.

End by asking the client how they feel toward these polarized parts now and what they notice in their body.

* Our conference table exercise adapts a technique developed by Richard Schwartz’s early IFS collaborator, Michi Rose.

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Therapist Handout**Other Ways of Visualizing Gatherings for Polarized Parts**

Any image can help polarized protectors unblend if it brings space, clarity, and an opportunity for perspective-taking. We offer some ideas here, but you can also invite clients to think of other options.

- Self sits with polarized protectors at a kitchen table or a banquet table.
- Self and polarized protectors gather around a campfire.
- Self sits on the floor with a classroom of polarized protectors who face each other.
- Self coaches or acts as the referee for polarized teams who gather on opposite sides of a net or a playing field.
- Self conducts an orchestra and polarized protectors are the musicians.
- Self is at a ranch and each group of parts has their own corral.

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Therapist Handout**Externalizing and Personifying Polarized Parts**

This exercise inquires into the motives and feelings of polarized parts by interviewing one part at a time. You and the client may be able to cover two parts in one session, but sometimes it's better to focus on just one. Let your intuition be your guide.

To begin, invite the client to place polarized parts in separate chairs (or different spots on a couch). Let the client know that they are going to embody one part at a time. Then ask all other parts, if they are willing, to relax back. If they have concerns, listen to and acknowledge these concerns until they're willing to step back. When everyone is ready, the client can sit in one chair and let that part take over. Then interview this part with the following questions:

- What is your job?
- Why do you do this job?
- What would happen if you stopped doing it?
- What do you want for the client?
- How old were you when you got this job?
- What is it like to do this job?
- Whom do you protect?
- What do you want the client to know?

When one interview feels complete, the client can go back to their original seat and describe the experience. When they are ready, or during the next therapy session, they can do the same for the opposing part. After these interviews, ask the client what they learned. How do they feel now toward the polarized parts?

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INTERVENING IN POLARIZATIONS

When firefighters are active, treatment providers tend to view them as the problem and ignore the internal criticism that managers dole out. In IFS, however, we map how each part affects other parts. Although it may take time for the client to map out the relevant pattern, they will recognize the behaviors and feelings they're naming as all too familiar.

When intervening with polarizing parts, we start by clarifying what drives the protectors (e.g., the need to engage in a distracting or soothing behavior versus the need to function and perform in various settings). When these parts are in overdrive, clients can feel confused and alarmed by their extreme rancor and impulsivity. In this regard, two tenets of the IFS model are immediately useful. First, constant conflict between protective parts is inevitable in an addictive system. Second, each team of parts, no matter how offensive, has positive intentions for the client.

For example, Santiago was a forty-two-year-old, Latinx, gay, cisgender high school teacher who first came to therapy for an overriding sense of depression, though he was also worried about his use of ecstasy and alcohol and his increasing impulsive sexual encounters that he considered risky. He had been in therapy for about six months. In this session, the therapist helped him identify his addiction polarity.

WORKING WITH A POLARITY



Santiago: I did it again this weekend. It's pretty crazy. I know I shouldn't go to apartments with strange guys. But I can't stop. When I get high, I don't care.

Therapist: Well, first, I appreciate your sharing this and being so honest. I'm know it's not easy.

Santiago: Yeah, you know I'd rather not discuss this. I mean it's fine to go out. I need to go out and do something besides read eleventh grade English papers. But last Saturday I got really messed up, and then I went with this guy—I guess to his place—which is really not cool of me to do. Why do I keep doing this? The guy was attractive but seemed kind of... a little too pleased with himself.